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Ruby-throated Hummingbird

*Archilochus colubris***QUICK STATS**

Length	2.8 – 3.5 in (7 – 9 cm)
Wingspan	3.1 – 4.3 in (8 – 11 cm)
Weight	0.07 – 0.21 oz (2 – 6 g)
Lifespan	Up to 9 years (avg. 3–5 in wild)

PRESENTATION

The Ruby-throated Hummingbird is the only hummingbird species that regularly breeds in eastern North America, and one of the most extraordinary birds on the continent. Weighing less than a nickel, it is a marvel of biological engineering: its wings beat 53 times per second, its heart beats up to 1,200 times per minute during flight, and it is the only bird capable of sustained backwards flight. The male's iridescent ruby-red gorget (throat patch) can appear jet black in poor lighting, then flash brilliant red as the angle of light changes — one of nature's most spectacular optical effects.

HABITAT & RANGE

During summer, the Ruby-throated Hummingbird breeds across the entire eastern half of North America, from Nova Scotia and Manitoba south through Florida and west to the Great Plains. It inhabits forest edges, gardens, orchards, and meadows with abundant flowering plants. Each fall, it undertakes one of the most astonishing migrations in the bird world: a non-stop flight of 500–900 miles across the Gulf of Mexico to its wintering grounds in Mexico and Central America. It returns north each spring from April through May.

DIET & FEEDING

- Flower nectar — trumpetvine, salvia, monarda, impatiens
- Feeder solution: 1 part white sugar to 4 parts water (no dye)
- Tiny insects and spiders — essential protein source
- Tree sap from sapsucker wells (used opportunistically)
- Never use honey, artificial sweeteners, or red dye in feeders

BEHAVIOR & SOCIAL LIFE

Ruby-throated Hummingbirds are among the most aggressively territorial birds in North America relative to their size. Males fiercely defend feeding territories, dive-bombing intruders — including birds many times their size — with surprising ferocity. Outside of courtship and mating, males and females live entirely solitary lives. To survive cold nights and food shortages, hummingbirds enter a state of torpor: their body temperature drops from 40°C to around 18°C, their heart rate falls from 1,200 to just 50 beats per minute, and their breathing nearly stops. This metabolic shutdown can save up to 60% of their nightly energy expenditure.

NESTING & BREEDING

The female alone builds one of nature's most remarkable nests: a walnut-sized cup of plant down and spider silk, camouflaged on the outside with lichens, and expandable as the chicks grow. It is typically placed on a slender downward-sloping branch 10–20 feet above ground. She lays exactly 2 white eggs the size of peas, incubating them alone for 11–14 days. She feeds the nestlings by inserting her bill deep into their throats and regurgitating nectar and insects. Young fledge at 18–22 days. The male plays no role in nesting or chick-rearing.

SONG & COMMUNICATION

Ruby-throated Hummingbirds are not known for melodious song. Their primary vocalizations are sharp, rapid chips and chattering calls used during territorial disputes and pursuit chases. Males perform spectacular U-shaped or pendulum dive displays during courtship, producing a distinctive wing-buzz at the bottom of each arc. The wingbeat itself produces the characteristic humming sound that gives the family its name.

CONSERVATION STATUS

IUCN Red List:	Least Concern	Population trend:	Stable
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With a stable population estimated at nearly 34 million individuals, the Ruby-throated Hummingbird is not currently threatened. However, it faces pressure from habitat loss on its wintering grounds in Central America and from climate change affecting the timing of flower blooms relative to migration. Planting native nectar plants and maintaining clean feeders are the most impactful ways to support local populations.

FEEDER TIPS

- Use a red feeder — no need to add dye to the solution
- Recipe: boil 1 cup white sugar in 4 cups water, cool completely
- Change solution every 2–3 days in hot weather to prevent fermentation
- Clean feeders with hot water and a bottle brush — no soap needed
- Hang feeders by late April in the South, mid-May in the North
- Plant trumpet vine, bee balm, salvia, and cardinal flower nearby

COLORING GUIDE

ZONE	RECOMMENDED COLOR
Back & crown (both)	Iridescent emerald green
Gorget — male throat	Ruby red (may look black)
Breast & belly	White to pale gray
Tail (male)	Forked, dark green-black
Female throat	White, no red gorget
Bill	Long, straight, black

COLOR ME!

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